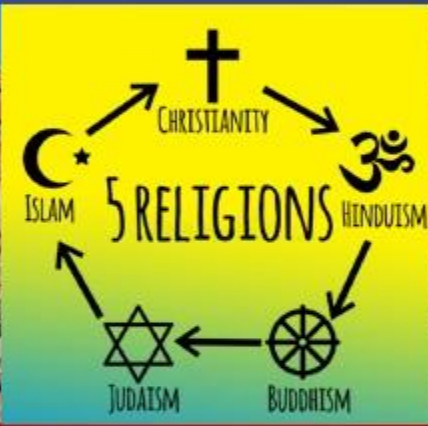


ART & CULTURE



INDIAN THEATRE

MODULE - 3

FOLK THEATRES

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

- Ankia Nat
- Kala
- Ramlila
- Raslila
- Bhuta

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

- Bhavai
 - Daskathia
 - Garodas
 - Jatra
 - Kariyila
 - Maach
 - Nautanki
- Swang
 - Tamasha
 - Villu Pattu
 - Oja-Pali
 - Pandavani
 - Powada

SOUTH INDIAN THEATRE

- Yakshagana
- Burra Katha
- Pagati Veshాలు
- Bayalata
- Tal-Maddale
- Theyyam
- Krishna Attam
- Kuruvañji

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

During the period of Bhakti movement, *folk theatre became a popular means for communicating faith to God*, both for the performer as well as audience. Some of the popular examples of such theatre are given below.



INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

1

ANKIA NAAT



1

It is the traditional one-act play of Assam.

2

It was started by the famous Vaishnava Saint Shankaradeva and his disciple Mahadeva in the 16th century A.D.

3

It is performed in the style of an opera and depicts incidents from the life of Krishna.

4

The Sutradhar or narrator is accompanied by a group of musicians known as **Gayan-Bayan Mandali** who play the “khol” and cymbals.

5

A particular presentation of an Ankia Naat is called a Bhaona.



A Sutradhar in Assamese Bhaona



A Street Play of Bhaona

2

RAMLILA

- 1 Ramlila is a popular folk theatre in the region of Uttar Pradesh.



- 2 Ramlila, literally “Rama’s play”, is a performance of Ramayana epic in a series of scenes that include song, narration, recital and dialogue.
- 3 It is performed across northern India during the festival of Dussehra, held each year according to the ritual calendar in autumn.
- 4 The most representative Ramlilas are those of Ayodhya, Ramnagar and Benares, Vrindavan, Almora, Sattna and Madhubani.



5 This staging of the Ramayana is based on the **Ramacharitmanas**, one of the most popular storytelling forms in the north of the country.

6 This sacred text devoted to the glory of Rama, the hero of the Ramayana, was composed by **Tulsidas**.

7 The majority of the Ramlilas recount episodes from the Ramacharitmanas through a series of performances lasting ten to twelve days.

2

RAMLILA

- 8 Ramlila recalls the battle between Rama and Ravana and consists of a series of dialogues between gods, sages and the faithful.



- 9 The Ramlila brings the whole population together, without distinction of caste, religion or age.



INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

2

RAMLILA

- 10** All the villagers participate spontaneously, playing roles or taking part in a variety of related activities, such as mask and costume making, and preparing make-up, effigies and lights.



- 11** However, the development of mass media, particularly television soap operas, is leading to a reduction in the audience of the Ramlila plays, which are therefore losing their principal role of bringing people and communities together.



INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

3

RASLILA

Raslila is a dance drama enactment of the adolescent love stories of Krishna and Radha.



4

BHUTA

Bhuta, which means spirit, is a traditional practise of worshipping the dead ancestors, prevalent in the Kannara District of Karnataka.



INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

RITUAL THEATRE

5

KALA



- 1 Kala is the ancient folk theatre of the **Vaishnavite tradition**.
- 2 It is mainly based around the lives and **incarnations of Vishnu**.
- 3 Some of the popular branches of Kala are Dashavatar Kala, Gopal Kala and Gaulan Kala.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

- This form of theatre was *more secular in its narration and story-telling.*
- They focused more on stories of love, valour and the socio-cultural traditions and were *meant primarily as means of entertainment for the rural areas.*



INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

1

BHAVAI

- 1 Bhavai is a popular folk theatre form of Gujarat and Rajasthan, mainly in the regions of Kutchh and Kathiawar.



- 2 This form incorporates an extensive use of dance to narrate a series of small plays, known as Vesha or Swang, each with its own plot.
- 3 The theme of the play is generally romantic.
- 4 The play is accompanied by a semi-classical music, played in a distinct folk style with instruments such as pakhawaj, Jhanjha, saarangi and tabla.
- 5 The Sutradhara is known as Nayaka in the Bhavai Theatre.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

2 DASKATHIA

- 1 Daskathia is a form of folk theatre popular in the region of Odisha.



- 2 In this form, there are two narrators – Gayaka, who is the chief singer and Palia, who is the co-narrator.
- 3 The Narration is accompanied by a dramatic music composed using a wooden musical instrument called Kathia.
- 4 A close variant of this form is the Chhaiti Ghoda, which uses two musical instruments dhol and mohuri and three narrators.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

2 DASKATHIA

5 They produce **spell binding performances** by changing their tone and pitch throughout along with the dancing.

6 To break the **monotony** they recite **humorous stories**.



7 The performance usually begins with an **invocation**, which in most cases is composed by local poets.

8 With the advent of modern medium of entertainment, it is fast losing its support base.

9 Till now, Daskathia troupes are being used as **major means of communication** for government's awareness programmes regarding health etc in rural areas.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

3

JATRA

- 1 Jatra is popular folk theatre of Eastern India. It is generally an open-air performance that was initiated by **Vaishnava saint Sri Chaitanya**.



- 2 During his travels through rural Bengal, he used the medium of Jatra to **propagate the teachings of Krishna**.
- 3 Later, variants such as Rama Jatra, Shiv Jatra and Chandi Jatra also came into existence that narrated stories from Puranic legends.
- 4 In the modern times, Jatra was used to **narrate stories of secular, historical and even patriotic themes**.
- 5 In Odisha, a popular form of street theatre known as **Sahi Jatra** is prevalent.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

4

MAACH



1 Maach is the folk theatre of the region of **Malwa** in **Madhya Pradesh**.

2 It originated in Ujjain around 17th century A.D. and was based on mythological themes.

3 In this theatre form **songs** are given prominence in between the dialogues.

4 The term for dialogue in this form is **bol** and rhyme in narration is termed **vanag**.

5 The tunes of this theatre form are known as **rangat**.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

5

SWANG



Nautanki and Saang had almost same roots.

- 1 Swang can be considered as the most ancient folk theatre form of India.
- 2 Swang is another popular source of entertainment in the region of Punjab and Haryana.
- 3 They are mainly musical dramas, sung through verses, accompanied by the music of ektara, harmonium, sarangi, dholak and khartal.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

6

NAUTANKI



- 1 An offshoot of Swang, Nautanki is the most popular form of theatre in North India, which found mention in Abul Fazl's Ain-e-Akbari.

- 2 The plays are themed around historical, social and folk tales and delivered through dance and music.

- 3 Dialogues are delivered in a lyrical fashion, accompanied by the beats of a drum called Nagara.

- 4 There was a time when only men acted in Nautanki but nowadays, women have also started taking part in the performances.

- 5 In the later period, two schools of Nautanki seated around Kanpur and Lucknow gained importance.



- 1 Tamasha is form of folk theatre in the region of Maharashtra, known for its humour and erotic content.

- 2 The unique feature of Tamasha is the presence of female actors, who play the even the male roles.

- 3 Classical music, footwork at lightning-speed, and vivid gestures make it possible to portray all the emotions through dance.

- 4 The Tamasha performances are generally accompanied by Lavani songs.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

8

POWADA



- 1 When Shivaji killed his adversary Afzal Khan, a play was written lauding the heroics of Shivaji, which later came to be known as Powada.
- 2 They are operatic ballads depicting stories of valour and sung by the folk musicians known as Gondhalis and Shahirs.
- 3 It is popular mainly in the region of Maharashtra.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

9

GARODAS



1 This is a popular art form of the “Garoda” community of Gujarat.

2 It uses painted pictures to narrate stories of romance and valour.



1

It is another form of **open-air theatre** that is popular in the foothills of Himachal Pradesh.

2

Generally staged during **villages fairs and festivals**, the performance occurs through the night and comprises of a series of small plays and skits.

INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

11

OJA-PALI

- 1 Oja-Pali is a unique narrative theatre form of Assam, primarily associated with the festival of **Manasa** or the **Serpent Goddess**.



- 2 The narration is prolonged affair, with three distinct parts **Baniya Khanda**, **Deva Khanda** and **Bhatiyali khanda**.
- 3 **Oja** is the main narrator and **Palis** are the members of the chorus.



INDIAN THEATRE

FOLK THEATRE

THEATRE OF ENTERTAINMENT

12

VILLU PATTU

The term “Villu Pattu” means **bow-song**. It is a form of musical theatre popular in the states of Kerala and Tamilnadu, in which stories of hero-worship are narrated using bow-shaped instruments.



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